

Plate tectonics: a short reading sample

Earth's outer shell is divided into moving plates. At divergent boundaries, plates move apart; at convergent boundaries, plates meet. Transform boundaries allow plates to slide past each other. These motions help explain the patterns of earthquakes, volcanoes, and mountain building.

Evidence to investigate

Matching fossils and rock layers across oceans suggest past continental movement.

Modern satellite positioning can measure present-day plate movement.

Study question: How would you distinguish motion from a competing explanation?